



Bridge Walk Anniversary

By [Jack Evans](#)

Tue 26 May 2020 at 3:00am



[Transcript](#)



REPORTER: Can you tell us why you're here?

GIRL: Just to respect our country.

MALCOLM FRASER: Well it's a great day, I hope it's a special moment for a lot of people.

GROUP: We've come to march for reconciliation.

WOMAN: Well I'm here from Brisbane and I'm here because I'm a Murri person and I need to live in this country with everybody else and reconciliation means a real lot to me.

JACK EVANS, REPORTER: On the 28th of May 2000 more than 250,000 thousand people, Indigenous and non-Indigenous, came together to walk across the Sydney Harbour Bridge for reconciliation. It was a day for healing and celebration. It was also the biggest political demonstration the country had ever seen. So how did it come about?

While Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people had been fighting for equality for years, in 1991 the government acknowledged there was still a long way to go, and it set up the Council for Aboriginal Reconciliation. It was given a ten-year mission to improve relationships between Indigenous and non-Indigenous people.

PATRICK DODSON: Our land has been used, our humanity was denied, our contribution ignored and our cries for justice and fairness were not heard.

It wouldn't be easy but over the next few years there were some big steps forward. In 1992 the Prime Minister at the time, Paul Keating, made the now famous Redfern Speech.

PAUL KEATING: The problem starts with us the non-Aboriginal Australians. It begins, I think, with an act of recognition. Recognition that it was we who did the dispossessing. We took the traditional lands and smashed the traditional way of life.

It was the first time a prime minister publicly addressed and acknowledged the devastating impact colonisation had on Australia's First People.

PAUL KEATING: We took the children from their mothers, we practiced discrimination and exclusion

The same year the Mabo decision was made. Meriam man Eddie Mabo convinced Australia's highest court to finally recognise that his people had legal rights to the land they'd lived on for thousands of years.

RICHARD MORECROFT, NEWS ANCHOR: The High Court has recognised there were people here and their descendants have rights.

It was huge and led to another big win, The Native Title Act of 1993 which recognises and protects Indigenous rights to land and water. The 90s also saw a big investigation into the forced removals of Indigenous children, known as the Stolen Generations. Between 1910 and 1970 thousands of Indigenous kids were taken by the Australian Government and placed on missions, orphanages or with white foster families.

JOY WILLIAMS: I thought I was an orphan, in fact I believed I was an orphan until I was about 12, 13 when I was told by the children's home that I had a mother and that I'd turn out to be a drunk and an alcoholic like my mother who was also Aboriginal and had mud in her veins and I was also told I had mud in my veins as well.

For a lot of Aussies, it was the first time they had heard these stories and it changed the way they thought about Indigenous Australians and the country's history. And as more stories were shared the push for reconciliation grew stronger.

In 2000 the Reconciliation Council decided to hold a massive two-day event during its recently created Reconciliation Week. It was called Corroboree 2000 and it included a meeting of high-profile Indigenous and non-Indigenous leaders, followed by the Walk for Reconciliation. Thousands of people showed up from all around Australia. In fact, the march lasted 6 hours, yeah it was big. And it wasn't the only march. There were several other reconciliation walks held around the country. Since the march there have been some big milestones for reconciliation

KEVIN RUDD: As Prime Minister of Australia, I am sorry.

But many Indigenous people say they're still fighting for recognition, equality and justice. And while this year Reconciliation Week is about celebrating how far we've come, it's also a reminder

that there is still a long way to go.

We take a look at an important event in the country’s history; the Walk for Reconciliation. On May 28th 2000, a quarter of a million Indigenous and non-Indigenous Australians walked across the Sydney Harbour Bridge to show the government of the time that they wanted justice and equity for all Australians. We find out more about the bridge walk, the events leading up to it, and its lasting impact on the country.

Credits

- [Jack Evans, Reporter](#)

Tue 26 May 2020 at 3:00am

Appears In

24 m

BTN Classroom Episode 14, 2020

5

In this episode

5 m

1 OF 5

PLAYING

Bridge Walk Anniversary

2m 27 s

2 OF 5

Bridge Walk Memories

4m 4s

3 OF 5

Creatives and COVID-19



4 OF 5

3m 4s

Tassie Tiger Video



5 OF 5

3m 4s

Pet Adoption during COVID-19



Contact BTN →

CONNECT WITH BTN



SECTIONS

- Home

Rookie Reporter
- BTN

Features
- BTN High

Subjects
- Stories

About
- BTN Live

GET THE BTN NEWSLETTER

Enter your email

SUBSCRIBE

Your information is being handled in accordance with the [ABC Privacy Collection Statement](#). This site is protected by reCAPTCHA and the Google [Privacy Policy](#) and [Terms of Service](#) apply.

ALL ABC NEWSLETTERS

Stay informed and connected with the ABC. Covering a wide range of topics and brands including News, iview, listen, and more.

[Browse all ABC newsletters](#) →



INFORMATION & SERVICES

[Editorial Policies](#)

[Accessibility](#)

[Help](#)

[Contact Us](#)

[Commercial](#)

[Careers](#)

[About the ABC](#)

[Privacy Policy](#)

[Terms of Use](#)

© 2026 ABC

FOLLOW THE ABC



We acknowledge Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples as the First Australians and Traditional Custodians of the lands where we live, learn and work.